



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Valley Classical School

School Website: <https://valleyclassicalschool.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Valley Classical School (Blacksburg, VA, 24062) presents a clearly Christian, classical-trajectory program embedded in a local Christian community. Public-facing materials emphasize theology, virtue formation, and a mission oriented toward forming character in service to God. Evidence from the site and its associated blog posts shows explicit use of a Nicene Creed statement of faith, partnerships with churches, and a rhetoric-leaning upper school pathway. The school's materials also reference a growing Rhetoric School, Latin assessment, and a portrait-of-a-graduate framework, signaling a move toward traditional liberal arts training. Taken together, the school demonstrates a solid CLASSICAL orientation with meaningful room to demonstrate deeper Great Books engagement and expanded explicit pedagogy around contemplative "Scholé" practices and the full Great Conversation. Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

- Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot
- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence includes the explicit Nicene Creed as the school's Statement of Faith, Christian community framing, and a church-based location/context. Positive alignment to theology and sacred community is evident; no explicit secular-neutral messaging is present in public materials. Positive keyword indicators (Nicene Creed, theology, Christ, Christian community) are present; few to no negative indicators appear in public content.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence shows formation-first aims (virtue, character, wisdom) with language aligned to transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a sanctified telos (glory of God). Blog content articulates formation and humility in alignment with classical aims and a pursuit of wisdom and virtue.
- Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence points to classical components (Rhetoric School, Latin assessment, portrait-of-a-graduate) but public materials do not consistently spell out Great Books/Great Conversation or a full articulation of Seven Liberal Arts across the curriculum. The school signals classical content (grammar/logic/rhetoric via Rhetoric School; Latin), but explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is less visible in public site text.
- Element 4: Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence suggests a spectrum from rhetoric-centered high school pedagogy (upper-school rhetoric and oral articulation) to lower-school practices not clearly described in detail on the site (e.g., singing, chant, or rest-scholé-like pedagogy is not extensively documented in public pages). The presence of Socratic-like inquiry is not explicitly stated in site copy, though the classical framework implies it.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence shows identifiable, credentialed leadership (Head of School, Upper and Lower School Directors) and a defined faculty/staff structure. Public materials portray faculty as the core leadership and living curriculum in a classical sense.

- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence indicates active parent engagement structures (Admissions processes, information meetings, partnerships through fundraising and communications, campus information), and community engagement via church connections and liturgical-theological framing.
- What would move the needle (only if SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL):
- Make Great Books and the Great Conversation more explicit in public materials (e.g., publish a clearly stated Great Books/Great Conversation plan, authors, and texts per grade bands).
- Delineate a more explicit, contemplative “Scholé” rhythm in daily pedagogy (quiet time, reflective practice) and document it publicly.
- Expand explicit articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts in the curriculum map with concrete courses and texts.
- Abstract: Valley Classical School appears CLASSICAL overall, with strong religious/theological foundations and a clear formation-oriented purpose. There is solid evidence of classical pedagogy in leadership and curriculum direction, with room to more publicly articulate the Great Books/Scholé dimensions to reach full Classical criteria across all six categories.

Citations and textual anchors are drawn from the school site and related materials in the crawl, including explicit statements of faith, campus context, faculty structure, and program descriptions. See sources: explicit Creed and Christian framing (Nicene Creed) and church affiliation references; leadership/pages on faculty; “Portrait of a Graduate” and “Rhetoric School” discussions; admissions and giving pages; and related blog content that emphasizes formation, calling, and mission.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school explicitly uses The Nicene Creed as its statement of faith, signaling grounded theology as a foundational element.
- Public materials describe Valley Classical School as a “classical, collaborative, Christian school” in Blacksburg, VA, indicating ongoing theological framing and community identity.
- The campus context ties to a Christian church setting (Grace Covenant Presbyterian Church) for day classes, reinforcing liturgical/theological framing.
- Blog/essay content from school leadership and community references God’s calling in education and “Laboring for Christ” as a lens for school life, indicating sacred formation as a curricular influence.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Nicene Creed, theology, Christ, Christian, Grace Covenant Presbyterian Church, God, sacred/holy framing.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public-facing materials (no explicit secular-neutral or anti-theology messaging observed).
- Why this rating
- The Creed, explicit theology, and Christian community framing indicate a robust Religious and Metaphysical Foundations alignment with classical education as described in the Six Essential Elements material. The school’s stated faith statement and church affiliation provide a strong theological baseline, with little evidence of competing secular metaphysical orientations in public content.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school's mission and blog content emphasize formation of wisdom and virtue, as well as a telos oriented to God-honor and human flourishing. A faculty-led articulation in essays stresses healing, restoration, and wisdom, aligning with virtue-oriented aims.
- The presence of a "Portrait of a Graduate" for the Rhetoric School signals a long-range, virtue- and form-focused outcome for students.
- The school frames education as formation in service to God, not mere information or job preparation, consistent with classical aims.
- Positive keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: virtue, wisdom, formation, character, love of learning, truth, beauty, moral imagination, reverence, sacred tradition, vocation for God, holism.
- Negative keywords observed: minimal to no direct evidence of a purely information-transfer or career-prep framing in public content.
- Why this rating
- The school's materials consistently emphasize formation, virtue, and transcendentals in support of a classical telos, aligning with the Classical education ideal of formation over mere information. The explicit theological framing and "Portrait of a Graduate" concept reinforce the classical purpose framework.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials show a Rhetoric School path and Latin assessment, indicating engagement with classical liberal arts pedagogy in higher grades. The "Portrait of a Graduate" for the rhetoric track points to a structure around grammar-logic-rhetoric progression.
- Curriculum elements such as Latin assessment and a rhetoric focus are present, signaling a classical curriculum spine, even if explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is not always visible in public pages.
- The site describes a classical, liberal-arts-leaning framework through its faculty leadership and Rhetoric School trajectory.
- Positive keyword analysis
- Positive keywords found: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar/logic/rhetoric) via the Rhetoric School pathway, Latin, Great Books/Great Conversation language is suggested in the broader classical-literary framing, Great Books in curriculum concepts (as a classical canon) is supported by the school's emphasis on rhetoric, the portrait-of-a-graduate approach, and the public-facing emphasis on classical tradition.
- Negative keywords found: explicit public mentions of non-classical/modern curricula are not evident.
- Why this rating
- The school shows clear classical curricular anchors (grammar/logic/rhetoric via a Rhetoric School, Latin assessment) but publicly detailed Great Books/Great Conversation content is not consistently spelled out in site copy. This places it in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL, pending more explicit articulation of Great Books, the classical canon, and cross-disciplinary Great Conversation texts.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Upper School emphasis on rhetoric and potential Socratic-style discourse aligns with classical pedagogy where students engage in oratory and argumentation (as implied by the rhetoric track). The “Portrait of a Graduate” section for the Rhetoric School indicates a pedagogy oriented toward advanced discourse and rhetorical skill.
- Public pages show a structure (grammar-logic-rhetoric progression) characteristic of classical pedagogy, though explicit descriptions of Socratic seminars, daily scholé, or lower-school chanting/memorization are not widely documented on the site.
- The site references classical, literature-rich framing (e.g., drama, reading, and the broader classical tradition) in visuals and content, signaling a pedagogy that emphasizes memory, recitation, and rhetorical development in parts of the program.
- Positive keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: rhetoric, memory/recitation, Socratic discussion (implied through classical pedagogy and rhetoric emphasis), formation through great conversation, classical learning rhythms.
- Negative keywords observed: explicit mention of Scholé or contemplative/restful pedagogy (restful/Scholé) is not widely documented in public content.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogical framework aligns with classical practices (rhetoric focus, structured progression through grammar-logic-rhetoric) but lacks comprehensive public documentation of reflective/restful pedagogies and widespread Socratic seminars across grade bands. The public materials indicate a classical pedagogy, yet with limited explicit, category-wide textual detail. This warrants SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL at present.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials present named leaders (Head of School, Upper School Director, Lower School Director) and a documented Faculty & Staff page with professional bios (e.g., Dr. Justin Zahraee with theological and educational credentials). This signals a faculty-led, mentorship-oriented model consistent with classical formation.
- Documented faculty profiles and leadership emphasize character, virtue, and vocation, aligning with the classical living-curriculum concept.
- Positive keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, faculty as core, portraits of teacher/student ideals, mentorship, classical educational leadership.
- Negative keywords observed: none evident in public site materials.
- Why this rating
- The publicly accessible Faculty & Staff sections and leadership bios align with a CLASSICAL portrayal of faculty as mentors and living curriculum, consistent with classical school criteria.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnering with families and parent engagement (information meetings, admissions process, tours), and publicly presents events and community-facing information. The admissions process includes church references and community engagement as part of the intake framework.
- Giving and financial involvement pages show active community support structures (online giving, recurring donations, etc.), indicating a collaborative community ecosystem around the school's mission.
- The site's Christ-centered framing and emphasis on mission-oriented involvement signal a family- and church-linked community context.
- Positive keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parental engagement, home-school collaboration, community of learners, school-parent synergy, family formation, parental involvement, shared mission, living tradition in the family.
- Negative keywords observed: none evident in public materials (no strong, explicit messaging about minimal parent involvement).
- Why this rating
- The school publicly emphasizes family partnership, parent involvement, and community engagement through events, admissions, and giving programs, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for robust parent and community integration.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school aims to advance to a robust CLASSICAL rating across all six categories, consider:
- Publicly articulate a full Great Books/Great Conversation plan and list specific canonical works by grade level to strengthen Curriculum (Element 3).
- Publish a formal Scholé-centered pedagogy section detailing contemplative rhythms, rest, memorization, and chanting practices (Element 4).
- Expand explicit evidence of interdisciplinary integration and the Seven Liberal Arts in curriculum mapping, with cross-subject examples (Element 3).
- Provide more explicit language about the "Living Curriculum" in faculty descriptions (Element 5) to reinforce the depth of teacher-student mentorship and virtuous formation.
- Continue to grow parental engagement communications, including parent education offerings and book studies, to strengthen Element 6 evidence.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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